In an interaction with INDIA TODAY, Governor Devvrat recounted his own experiences with natural farming. "Due to decades of pesticide abuse, soil fertility has been the biggest casualty," he says. "Any soil whose organic carbon content is less than 0.5 per cent is barren. Before the 'Green Revolution', the organic carbon content in our soil was 2-2.5 per cent; now, it is 0.2-0.3 per cent. So, our soil is beyond barren. Our food crops are drawing very little nutrients from the soil and are completely dependent on fertilisers." This means farmers are increasingly at the mercy of private players or government subsidies. The GoI currently spends Rs 1.25 lakh crore a year on urea and DAP subsidies. And some 83 per cent of India's farmers are small and marginal, who cannot bear the additional costs of production.

Since the concept of natural farming is extremely dear to him, Devvrat introduced it soon after he came to Gujarat in 2019. It immediately found support from the state government. Special financial assistance was announced in the 2020 state budget to promote natural farming practices under the Gujarat Aatmanirbhar package. Every farmer is entitled to a subsidy of Rs 1,248 to buy a natural farming kit to prepare Jivamrut and another Rs 900 a month to maintain a cow. The Gujarat Prakrutik Krushi Vikas Board was also formed to boost natural farming, with Rs 100 crore allocated in the 2022 budget. And while earlier you had to go to the nearest agriculture university to get training for natural farming, since May 2023, a team consisting of a member of the village's '*sakhi mandal*', one farmer and one agriculture expert from the university, has started visiting villages to impart such training. As a result, 2.3 million farmers have been trained in eight months. The government has also sanctioned the first-ever Natural Farming Science University, at Halol in Panchmahal district. ■

